proclamation of 1812 that abolished the buying and selling of all slaves in Travancore and for measures introduced in 1815 that gave lower-caste tenant farmers such as the Ezhavas and Nadars greater rights.[13]

Here I must admit to a degree of partiality, because in 1810 John Munro married Charlotte Blacker, whose family are among my more distant ancestors. So the reader should be aware of unconscious bias in all that I have written concerning Munro. I should also point out that Munro was an ardent Christian Evangelical and a committed supporter of the Church Missionary Society, which under the leadership of William Ringeltaube and a Tamil Christian named Vedamanikkam was given permission to set up a church at Mailadi in south Travancore. Initially they enjoyed great success in attracting the more oppressed sections of the local Nadar toddy-tappers, the Shanars, who in addition to all the other taxes were having to pay an *enikanam* tax for the ladders and a *thalaikanam* tax for the rope-belts they used to climb the palmyra trees. 'There was a rush of 5000 Shanars upon me,' wrote the missionary Ringeltaube in a letter to John Munro in March 1818, 'who had been long waiting for an opportunity to shake off the poll-tax and services attached to their caste and which they hoped to effect by connecting themselves with me. But when they found that no temporal advantages were to be obtained, their zeal for the Protestant religion collapsed.'[14]

I suspect that it was on Munro's advice that in 1812 the queen issued a proclamation allowing Nadar converts to Christianity to cover their breasts with *kuppayam* blouses as worn by Syrian Christian women, followed two years later by a proclamation that exempted Syrian and other Christians from paying taxes for the maintenance of Hindu temples – steps that were deeply resented by the Brahmins and other sections of the community.